



SALARY GUIDE 2026

Accounting & Finance

What accounting and finance people are asking to be paid, why they're looking, where they'll work, and how to hire them before you need them.

\$95K

Typical ask for a Senior Accountant

35%

Are looking for growth or a next step

4%

Named pay as the reason they're looking

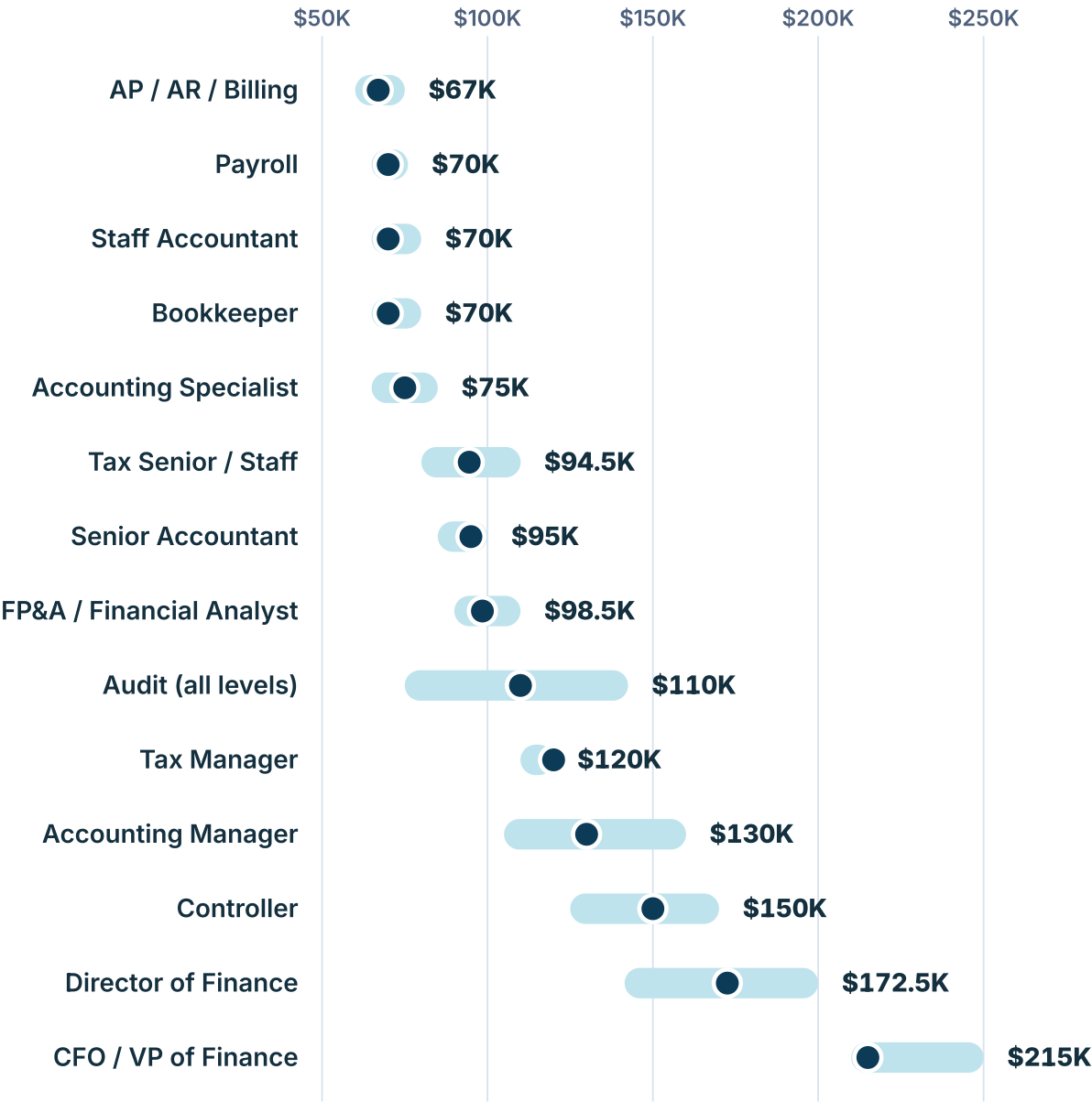
84%

Would work hybrid

Built from 1,447 Staff Financial Group and NorthPoint Search Group candidate questionnaires and job applications (January–October 2026) and U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics data.

What they're asking to be paid

Desired base salary, from 805 candidates who told us what they want in their next role.
The bar is the middle half of answers. The dot is the typical ask (the median).



The lowest salary people say they'd accept sits close to what they ask for. A Senior Accountant asking \$95K says the floor is about \$87.5K. There isn't much room to come in low.

TITLE	ANSWERS	MIDDLE HALF	TYPICAL ASK	LOWEST THEY'D TAKE
AP / AR / Billing	55	\$60K – \$75K	\$67K	—
Payroll	9	\$65K – \$76K	\$70K	\$62.5K
Staff Accountant	113	\$65K – \$80K	\$70K	\$70K
Bookkeeper	28	\$65K – \$80K	\$70K	\$60K
Accounting Specialist / Associate	61	\$65K – \$85K	\$75K	\$70K
Tax Senior / Staff	60	\$80K – \$110K	\$94.5K	\$76K
Senior Accountant	105	\$85K – \$100K	\$95K	\$87.5K
FP&A / Financial Analyst	38	\$90K – \$110K	\$98.5K	\$95K
Audit (all levels)	7	\$75K – \$142.5K	\$110K	\$90K
Tax Manager	14	\$110K – \$120K	\$120K	—
Accounting Manager / Supervisor	81	\$105K – \$160K	\$130K	\$118K
Controller	122	\$125K – \$170K	\$150K	\$137.5K
Director of Finance / Accounting	28	\$141.5K – \$200K	\$172.5K	\$170K
CFO / VP of Finance	84	\$210K – \$250K	\$215K	\$210K

Government numbers for comparison

Median annual pay, metro Atlanta, May 2025 (BLS). These include every experience level, so they can run lower than what experienced candidates ask for.

Financial managers (controllers, finance directors)	\$171,240
Financial and investment analysts	\$100,830
Accountants and auditors	\$85,820
Payroll and timekeeping clerks	\$62,710
Bookkeeping, accounting and auditing clerks	\$51,170

How to read this

Asking pay is base salary only, before bonus and benefits. Titles with fewer than 5 answers aren't shown. About 35% of candidates who gave a location are in Georgia; the rest are spread across the U.S.

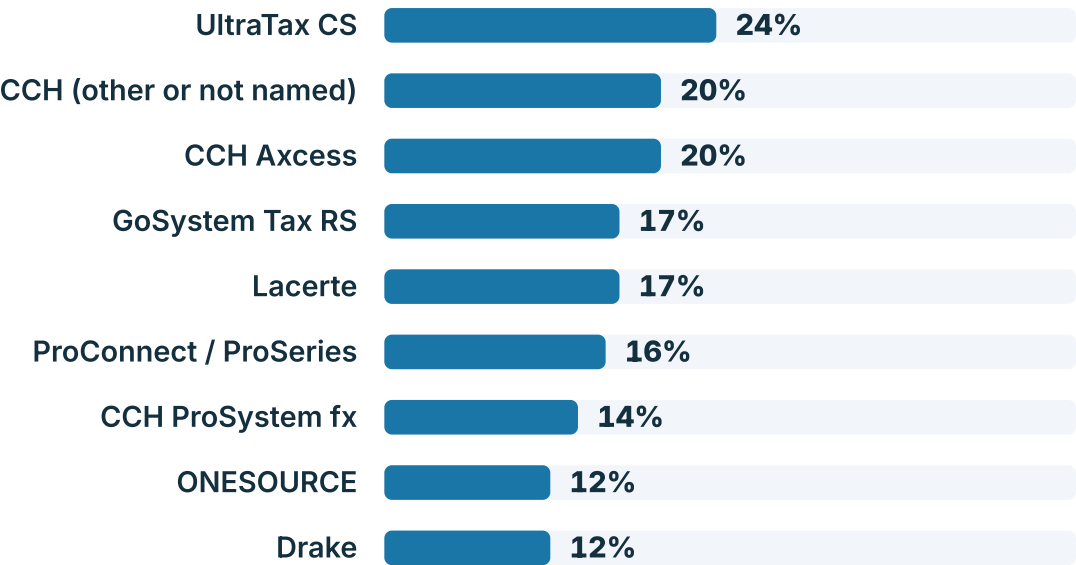
Tax and audit people

From 114 tax and audit candidates who answered our tax screening questions, plus the pay asks above.

TITLE	ANSWERS	MIDDLE HALF	TYPICAL ASK
Tax Senior / Staff	60	\$80K – \$110K	\$94.5K
Tax Manager	14	\$110K – \$120K	\$120K
Audit (all levels)	7	\$75K – \$142.5K	\$110K

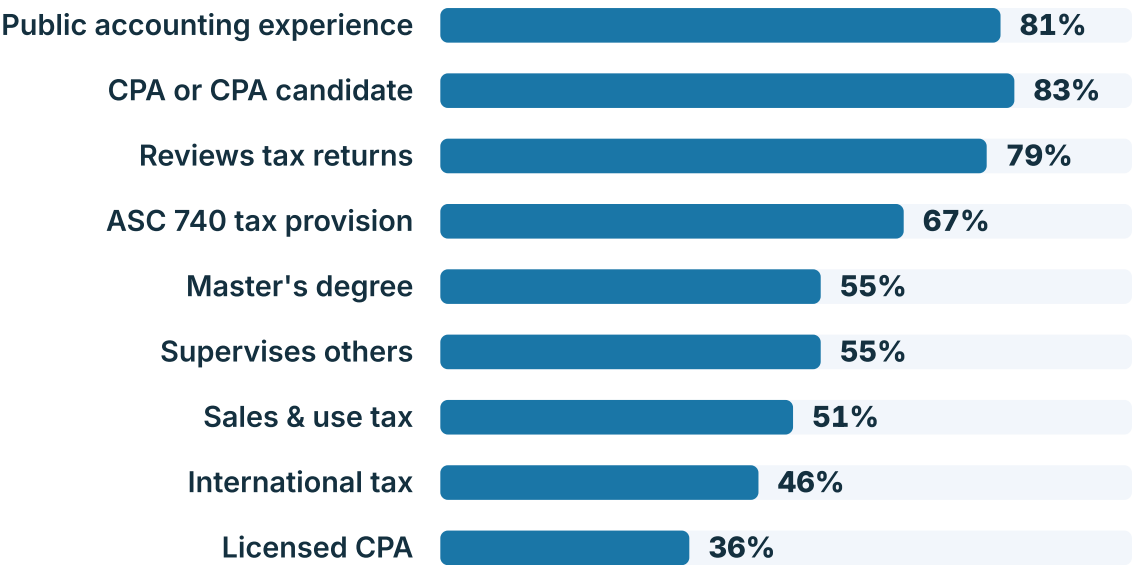
Tax software they know

From 113 candidates. Many know more than one.



Their experience

Each bar is the share of people who answered that question (39 to 91 answers each).

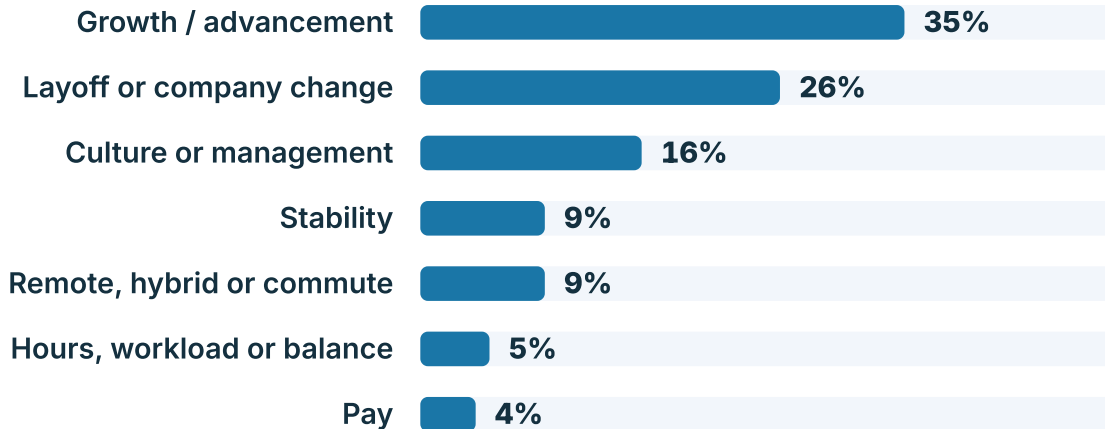


UltraTax CS and the CCH products lead. 81% come from public accounting, and 83% are CPAs or working toward it (36% are licensed). If you need ASC 740 or international tax, ask up front: 67% and 46% have it.

WHY THEY MOVE

Growth beats pay

Why they're looking, from 620 candidates who answered in their own words. Many gave more than one reason, so the bars add up to more than 100%.

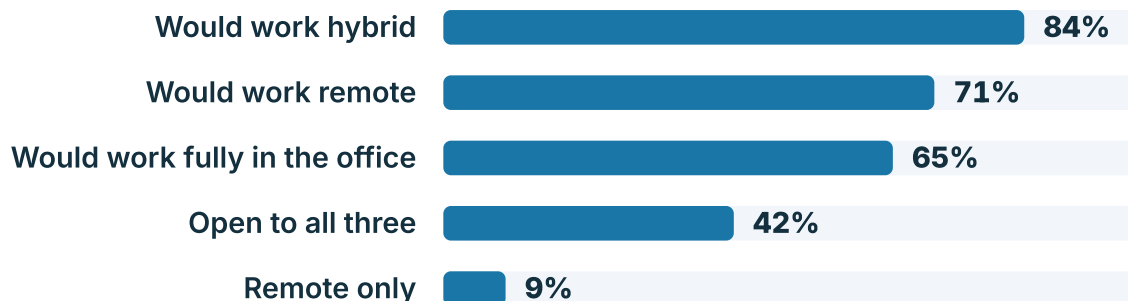


35% are looking for growth or a next step. Only 4% named pay. 26% are on the market because of a layoff or a change at their company, so good people are available right now.

WHERE THEY'LL WORK

Hybrid works for almost everyone

From 736 candidates. They could pick every setup they'd accept.

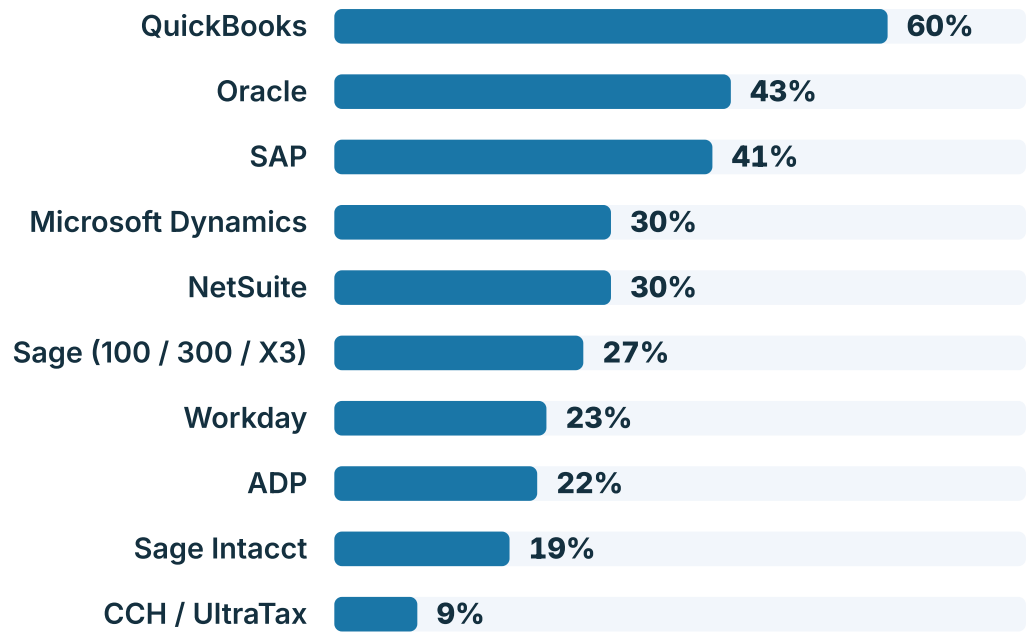


84% would work hybrid and 65% would work fully in the office. Only 9% will only work remote. You don't need a fully remote job to compete.

SYSTEMS

The software they know

Accounting and payroll systems named by 820 candidates. Many know more than one.



QuickBooks is the most common: 60% know it. Oracle and SAP follow at 43% and 41%. If you run something else, ask about it in your screening questions.

TURNOVER

How often people leave

Departures per 100 jobs in a year (all separations, 2025), from the BLS Job Openings and Labor Turnover Survey.



How long people stay

Median years with their current employer, January 2026 (BLS).

Management (incl. controllers, CFOs)	6.1 years
Business and financial operations (incl. accountants)	4.6 years
Office and administrative support (incl. AP, payroll, bookkeeping)	4.1 years
All occupations	4.1 years

What that means for a team of 10

At professional services employers, a 10-person accounting team sees 5 or 6 departures a year. At finance and insurance employers it's 2 or 3. Either way, most of those openings are predictable.

A year is 12 times the average monthly rate. It counts departures, so one seat can turn over more than once.

WHAT TO DO

Five ways to hire better this year

1. Price to the ask.

Put the middle-half range for the role in your job post. Candidates' floor is close to their ask, so low offers lose people.

2. Sell the path, not just the pay.

35% are looking for growth. Show the next title, who they'll learn from, and what they'll own.

3. Offer hybrid.

84% will work hybrid. Only 9% insist on remote.

4. Screen for your system.

Ask about your ERP and tax software up front. Train the rest.

5. Build the bench before you need it.

Turnover is predictable. Keep a short list of ready people behind every seat so the next resignation is a phone call, not a crisis.

Accounting and finance recruiting, done for you.

For every search, Staff Financial Group builds a custom screening questionnaire with you, so every résumé arrives with your questions already answered. Candidates can add a short video intro. Direct hires come with a replacement guarantee, and we can payroll contract hires for you.

Start a search → stafffinancial.com

METHOD AND SOURCES

Pay, reasons, work setup and software come from screening questionnaires and job applications that candidates completed for Staff Financial Group and NorthPoint Search Group between January 1, 2026 and October 2, 2026: 1,447 people, newest form per person. Pay figures are desired base salary for the titles shown; the middle half is the 25th to 75th percentile, rounded to \$500. Groups with fewer than 5 answers are left out, and no individual answer is shown.

- BLS Job Openings and Labor Turnover Survey, 2025 annual averages (released March 13, 2026), Tables 20 and 22.
- BLS Employee Tenure, median years with current employer by occupation, January 2026, Table 6.
- BLS Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics, May 2025, Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell, GA.